territorial integrity would be the paramount concern.[78] Indira believed that only a stronger and more united India ‘would we be able to stand up to other nations.’[79] Under her leadership, the Indian state became increasingly concerned about its security and defence, something that had not received Nehru’s full attention.

Under Indira Gandhi, Indian strategists embraced the belief that India’s security would be negatively impacted unless its smaller neighbours followed pro-Indian foreign policies. This led to what has come to be known as the Indira doctrine whose core principles were firstly that ‘no foreign power should be allowed to cross the crest of the Himalayas’ and secondly that ‘India would consider the presence or influence of an external power in the region as adverse to its interests unless that power recognized Indian predominance’.[80] The Indira doctrine was in effect a South Asian equivalent of the US Monroe doctrine. It led to actions during the East Pakistan crisis leading to India’s military victory in 1971 against Pakistan, which, as Dixit points out, ‘restored national self-confidence’ after the 1962 military loss against China.[81]

Indira explained the contours of what became known as the Indira doctrine in a 1970 seminar organized by the Congress party. Like her father, she insisted that foreign policy was based on both history and geography and hence the way India looked at things would differ from other countries. Indira stated that under her father India was able to make a mark on the international stage even though it lacked economic and military strength. This was because India was ‘in the forefront of the freedom struggle’ and had ‘leaders of stature’.[82] The realist in Indira acknowledged that India no longer punched above her weight, as it had been able to do under Nehru. However, Indira’s strategy for increasing India’s international weight was not alignment with one of the superpowers. It lay in building India’s economic and military strength, preferably indigenously. Under Indira,